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Everyone Thought They Knew the Amanda Knox Story in 2007. But a New Show Proves We Had No Idea.

If you were sentient in 2007, it was hard not to be aware of the Amanda Knox story. A British exchange student named Meredith Kercher was raped and murdered at the student apartment in Perugia, Italy, that she shared with three other girls—two Italians and an American. The American, Amanda Knox, and Knox's boyfriend of eight days, Raffaele Sollecito, were held for questioning.

Under questioning, Knox confessed, implicating Patrick Lumumba, the Congolese owner of the café where she worked part time, by saying she and Sollecito had been in the room when Lumumba killed Kercher. Although she retracted her statement the next day, all three were arrested. However, Lumumba had a tight alibi and, two weeks later, was released without charge. At the same time, the Italian police detained Rudy Guede, a drifter and small-time criminal with a history of sexual assault, leaking a lurid theory that Knox, Sollecito, and Guede had indulged in a drug-fueled sex game with Kercher that went wrong, resulting in Kercher's death. All three were arrested.

The combination of sex, drugs, and an attractive young female (alleged) villainess sent the media—especially the Italian and British tabloids—into overdrive. Guede stood trial and was convicted of Kercher's murder only a month after his arrest, but Sollecito and Knox languished in jail for another two years before having their day in court. In 2009 they were both found guilty of murder and sentenced to 25 and 26 years, respectively. Two years later, the verdicts were overturned on appeal, but in 2014, the convictions were reinstated until the pair were finally exonerated the following year by Italy's highest court.

The Twisted Tale of Amanda Knox, a new series out now on Hulu, attempts to follow the ins and outs of all these legal reversals, hence the title. It is based largely on Knox's 2013 memoir *Waiting to Be Heard*, and a disclaimer at the start of each episode mentions that the show privileges her point of view, a stance underlined by Knox's credit as an executive producer. Another executive producer is Monica Lewinsky, who knows all about being a photogenic young woman at the center of a media firestorm splashing details of her sexual history over every front page and evening news broadcast as she loses any expectation of privacy.

The voice that remains unheard in the series, as in the trial and its aftermath, is Kercher's. Her family retained a dignified silence during all the court proceedings and has made no comment on the show [beyond her sister saying](#), "Our family has been through so much, and it is difficult to understand how this serves any purpose." Given that the series represents Knox's version of events, it is hard to say if any deviations from reality represent an actual departure from the truth or just an overly faithful adherence to Knox's partisan version, but in any case, we herein attempt to discover what's fact and what's fiction in this undeniably twisted tale.

Did Knox Confess Under Coercion?

In the show, Amanda is questioned, then is released, then voluntarily returns for further questioning three days after Meredith's murder has been discovered, after the police say they want to clear up a few details with her. Completely unaware that she is a possible suspect and believing the police when they say she is just a witness, she is happy to cooperate.

When she gets to the police station, she is made to wait for hours, then questioned by several Italian detectives simultaneously. Although her Italian is rudimentary, she isn't offered an interpreter and so

doesn't understand many of the questions put to her. Nor does she have a lawyer because, having led a sheltered existence as a middle-class American, she has a remarkably trusting attitude toward the authorities, assuming that since she's innocent, she doesn't need one. The police ignore guidelines and fail to record the interview.

Amanda is subjected to techniques designed to confuse and demoralize her, both physical—such as not letting her go to the bathroom even when she needs to change a tampon, keeping her awake without food for several hours, and even hitting her—and psychological—such as lying to her about evidence, making her doubt her own version of events, and suggesting she is having false memories. Worn down and desperate to make it stop, Amanda tells the police she saw her employer and friend Patrick kill Meredith.

In a 2016 interview with *Nightline*, Knox said that this questioning lasted 53 hours, during which time she changed her story from maintaining she had spent the night with Sollecito in his apartment to asserting she had been in the girls' apartment when Kercher was killed. This was because “the police told me that I had amnesia and that I better remember the truth,” [she said](#). “And so what they were forcing me to consider was that my memories that I had—that I had spent the night with Raffaele—were wrong.” Furthermore, she alleged, “I was hit on the back of the head, I was yelled at. Police were coming in and out of the room, telling me that I was a liar.”

Then, earlier this year, she [told the Atlantic](#), “They lied to me: *We have hard evidence placing you at the scene of the crime that night. We know you were there.* Like many people, I had assumed that the police were bound by some code of ethics to tell the truth. I could not fathom that they would, or even could, lie to me. All of this—compounded by the bullying, exhaustion, promises, and threats—reshaped my sense of reality, and made it hard to know what was true and what wasn't.”

Knox was contacted in prison by Saul Kassin, a psychologist and an expert in false confessions, who told her that isolation, bullying, nitpicking of memories, long interrogations, the refusal of food and bathroom breaks, and deception were established techniques for eliciting false confessions. He drew a comparison with the treatment of the Central Park Five, five teenagers—four of them Black, one Latino—who were questioned by police over several hours without parents or lawyers present, similarly operating under pressure from top brass for a quick conviction and a media pack baying for blood, with the boys ultimately falsely confessing to murdering a white female jogger in Central Park. And indeed the scenes of Knox's questioning in the series very much recall the interrogation scenes in [When They See Us](#), Ava DuVernay's disturbing dramatization of that other infamous miscarriage of justice.

In 2019 the European Court of Human Rights [supported Knox's version of events](#), finding that her human rights had been violated during the interrogation due to a police failure to provide legal assistance and an independent interpreter, and ordered Italy to pay Knox damages. However, the court also found that there was insufficient evidence to conclude that she had “sustained inhuman or degrading treatment.”



Knox's mother, Edda Mellas; Mellas as played by Shannon Horgan in *The Twisted Tale of Amanda*

Knox. Photo illustration by Slate. Photos by Giuseppe Bellini/Getty Images and Disney/David Astorga.

Did Knox Recant Her Statement?

After Amanda confesses, she is allowed to go home and go to sleep. When she wakes up, she is able to remember the events of the night of the murder more clearly and writes them down in a note she gives to the police in a desperate attempt to recant her accusation against Patrick.

Ironically, it was Knox's accusation of Lumumba that did the most to undermine her case. He brought a civil suit for slander, which was tried concurrently with her murder charge and heard by the same jury. The dubious confessions were not admissible in the murder trial, but they were admissible in the civil case, so the jury was able to hear them. Even after the murder conviction was overturned, Knox's slander conviction remained. Following the ECHR's ruling that her interrogation had not been properly conducted, Italy's high court ordered a new trial to consider the slander verdict. There was only one piece of evidence: the four-page handwritten letter Knox had given to the police the day after she was released from questioning.

[In it, she says](#), "In regards to this 'confession' that I made last night, I want to make clear that I'm very doubtful of the verity of my statements because they were made under the pressures of stress, shock, and extreme exhaustion." But she doesn't actually withdraw the accusation, writing only, "In these flashbacks that I'm having I see Patrik as the murderer, but the way the truth feels in my mind, there is no way for me to have known, because I don't remember FOR SURE if I was at my house that night."

The slander appeal failed, and the conviction remains.

While Knox and Sollecito suffered years of imprisonment for a crime they didn't commit, with Knox being demonized in the court of public opinion by prosecutors—she recalled that they characterized her using words like *dirty*, *witch*, *murderer*, *slanderer*, *demon*, *depraved*, *impostor*, *promiscuous*, *succubus*, *evil*, *pervert*, *dissolute*, and *psychopath*—Lumumba, who would not have been dragged into the whole affair were it not for Knox's blurting out his name, lost the business he had built up and ultimately left Italy for Poland.

At the beginning of 2025, Lumumba's lawyer noted that Knox had never offered to make financial amends to Lumumba and had never really apologized for blowing up his life. However, in 2024, Knox had [offered an apology of sorts](#), saying, "I am very sorry I was not strong enough to resist the pressure of the police and that he suffered for it." For Americans, the whole episode had uncomfortable echoes of the unfortunate tradition of a white woman trying to get herself out of trouble by putting the blame on a Black man.

Was the DNA Evidence Really So Badly Handled?

In its depiction of Knox and Sollecito's first trial, the series shows the prosecution's DNA expert testifying that a knife found in the murder flat's cutlery drawer had traces of Meredith's DNA on the blade and Amanda's DNA on the handle. The other supposedly damning evidence was a bra fastener that had all three defendants' DNA on it, as well as the victim's.

But by the time of the 2011 appeal trial, a damning video of the police's evidence gathering at the crime scene has emerged, and two independent experts completely refute the original trial's DNA

evidence by revealing a truly astonishing lack of rigor in the evidence collection and thus a high likelihood of contamination. As physical proof linking Amanda and Raffaele to the crime scene is very thin on the ground, this comprehensively undermines the prosecution's case.

This is in fact what happened. In the first 2011 appeal, the judge was influenced by the testimony of two independent DNA experts from Sapienza University in Rome. One testified that there were several times when forensic police entered the crime scene without wearing protective masks or hair caps and that they often used plastic bags, rather than paper, to wrap evidence, heightening the risk of contamination.

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Another expert maintained that there wasn't enough of a DNA sample on the knife blade to attribute it to Kercher with certainty and that the original testing did not meet international standards.

As for the bra clasp, it was not collected from Kercher's room until 46 days after her body was discovered. During this period, the clasp was moved to different locations around the room, with video showing police officers not following proper procedures in their handling of it, using nonsterile gloves, failing to change gloves after touching a surface or item, and dropping it on the floor.

Were Kercher and Knox Friends or Frenemies?

The early part of the series depicts Meredith and Amanda as being good friends, hanging out and having fun like normal student roommates—talking about boys, smoking pot, putting on makeup together, laughing as they walk around Perugia—but when questioned by the police, Meredith's British friends say she didn't like Amanda that much and was angry with her for not doing her share of the cleaning and for bringing random hookups to the house. One of the two Italian roommates confirms this view.

In reality, only Kercher and Knox would know how close they actually were. They were certainly friendly enough to go to a chocolate festival together and, the week before the murder, to the

concert where Knox met Sollecito. However, Knox undermined her own account of a close friendship during her initial trial. When asked if she ever thought about the victim, she [responded by saying](#): “In the end, I knew her for a month. And first of all, I’m trying to get on with my life.”

But even if there were some friction over fairly routine domestic irritations between roommates, it is hard to believe that they would drive Knox from being a somewhat ditzy 20-year-old with no history of criminality, let alone violence, to, as the prosecution’s video reconstruction alleged, repeatedly banging Kercher’s head against a wall and trying to strangle her. No motive was ever established beyond the prosecution’s unsubstantiated assertion of a drug-and-sex-induced frenzy.

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